

SERIES

Peace and rearmament

All the pieces in the series in a single document, in reading order. Updated 8 November 2026.

How Europe responds to threats: how fast it arms, how slowly it negotiates, and who pays. It starts with the supermarket freezers tampered with remotely on 2 November, to separate facts from suspicion, and with a signed Opinion on the asymmetry between defence and diplomacy. Two Analyses will follow: the bill for rearmament and the limits of self-defence.

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Freezers at 50 degrees: who attacked Europe's supermarkets, and what we really know

In brief

- On the night of 1 to 2 November cyberattacks tampered with the refrigeration systems of supermarkets in at least eleven European countries, Italy included. In many cases freezers were pushed to 50 degrees. Tonnes of food were thrown away.
- It repeated an attack carried out in France on 12 October. In both cases the target was remote-control software, partly outdated and exposed online without adequate protection.
- On 4 November two pro-Russian groups, NoName057(16) and Z-Pentest, claimed the attacks on Telegram. The messages were later deleted and nobody has verified them independently.
- In 2025 the United States and Denmark had already pointed to links between these groups and the Russian state; according to the American indictment, Z-Pentest is another name for a group directed by Russian military intelligence. For the attacks on the fridges, however, no authority has published evidence of state direction. The Kremlin denies it.
- Under international law the difference is decisive: a state is responsible for what its organs do, or those acting under its control, not for what sympathisers do. But it also has a duty not to let its territory be used to harm others.

A supermarket fridge is an ordinary object. It becomes less ordinary when you discover that, to make it go haywire, you do not need to enter the shop: you only need to find online the panel that controls it. On the night of 2 November someone did this in hundreds of stores, from Dublin to Bucharest. Who did it is the question on which, within a few days, an entire political reading was built. This piece tries to separate what we know from what is being said.

THE FACTS

France, 12 October. The first attack in this series hit several hundred French supermarkets. Police counted about 700 refrigeration units tampered with, in chains such as Intermarché, Coopérative U, Carrefour, Leclerc and Monoprix, with damage above 130,000 euros (GreenMe). The attackers had exploited old versions of Danfoss software for remote monitoring of the systems (Informat.ro). According to an expert quoted by CNN, more than 1,700 installations of that software were visible online before the attack (QN).

Europe, 2 November. Three weeks later the same technique was repeated on a continental scale. The attackers switched the evaporators of fridges and freezers into defrost mode, pushing temperatures up to 50 degrees (Teleborsa; Cybernews). At least eleven countries were hit (Euronews); other sources count twelve, including Belgium, the Netherlands, Sweden, Estonia, Ireland, Germany, Romania and Portugal (RetailDetail). In Ireland the SuperValu chain pulled products from 13 stores; in Belgium Carrefour spoke of about 15 outlets out of 700 (Cybernews; TweakTown).

Italy. Attacks were recorded in Sicily, at least three stores in Catania and one in Palermo, as well as in Tuscany and Emilia-Romagna, where the National Cybersecurity Agency identified one against a frozen-food company (Open). On 3 November the government convened the Agency and the heads of the intelligence services at Palazzo Chigi; the final statement spoke of a limited impact on the distribution chain (ItaliaOggi).

The investigations. In Belgium prosecutors opened a criminal investigation (Al Jazeera). The European Commission convened agencies and national authorities, but did not attribute the attacks to any state or group (Informat.ro). Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen called them a deliberate attempt to hit the food supply chain (Informat.ro).

WHO DID IT: THREE LEVELS NOT TO CONFUSE

1. The claim. On 4 November NoName057(16) and Z-Pentest jointly claimed the attacks, with a video and some Telegram messages that were later deleted. NoName057(16) also reportedly published a sample of more than 2,500 lines with usernames and passwords of Danfoss employees and customers. Nobody has verified it. A researcher quoted by Cybernews doubts that the groups actually breached the systems, rather than taking credit after the media had named them as suspects (Cybernews). According to Agenda Digitale, the statement contains no exclusive technical data that only the perpetrators could know (Agenda Digitale).

2. The groups' links to Moscow. Here there is evidence, but it concerns the past. On 9 December 2025 the US Department of Justice brought charges describing the Russian government's support for NoName057(16) and for another group, Cyber Army of Russia Reborn, which according to the indictment also uses the name Z-Pentest and was founded, funded and directed by Russian military intelligence, the GRU (Kyiv Independent). A few days later Denmark attributed to Z-Pentest a 2024 attack on a water treatment plant. According to the security firm Forescout, since the start of 2026 Russia-based groups have claimed at least 20 attacks on refrigeration systems (Pillitteri, summarising the DOJ, the Danish government and Forescout). The suspicion, then, does not come from nowhere.

3. Direction by the Russian state. This is the unproven part. For the attacks on the fridges no authority has published evidence of state direction (same source). The Kremlin called the accusations "absurd" (AFP, via Macau Business). A Belgian expert said he was "95% sure" it was Russian sabotage (RetailDetail): that is a professional assessment, not proof.

The jump from the first level to the third is the one public debate made fastest. In Italy, for example, the government spoke of a Russian lead on 3 November, before any claim of responsibility (Pillitteri).

THE WEAK SPOT

Whoever the perpetrator, the door was open. According to security experts, about 13,000 refrigeration systems in Europe still run on outdated software with known vulnerabilities (dev.ua). Until this wave, nobody had thought these systems needed high-level cyber defences (QN). The countermeasures set out by the French agency CERT-FR are simple: take the systems off direct internet access, change default passwords, update the firmware, and reopen access only through a VPN (Pillitteri). On 4 November in France an attack of the same kind against the cold rooms of three blood storage centres was foiled (Liga.net).

LEGAL COMMENTARY

When an attack belongs to a state. Under international law a state is responsible for the actions of its organs and of persons or groups acting on its instructions, or under its direction or control (articles 4 and 8 of the International Law Commission's Articles on State Responsibility, 2001). In Nicaragua v. United States (1986) the International Court of Justice required "effective control" over the specific operations (ICJ). General support, or political sympathy, is not enough.

The duty of vigilance. There is, however, a second obligation. As early as 1949, in the Corfu Channel case, the Court held that no state may knowingly allow its territory to be used for acts contrary to the rights of other states (ICJ). If groups known to a country's authorities repeatedly hit another country's infrastructure, the state from which they operate has a duty to stop them, even if it does not direct them.

What kind of violation. Remotely damaging another country's civilian installations, with economic losses but without deaths or destruction comparable to military action, hardly reaches the threshold of an "armed attack" that allows self-defence (Article 51 of the UN Charter). It is closer to a violation of sovereignty or of the prohibition of intervention. The permitted responses are therefore of another kind: investigations, diplomatic measures, sanctions. Since 2019 the EU has had a specific sanctions regime for cyberattacks.

SYMMETRY TEST

The same yardstick for evidence. If we demand public proof before attributing an attack to Moscow, the same demand applies to cyberattacks the press attributes to Western states, such as the Stuxnet virus against Iranian centrifuges, which the United States and Israel have never officially acknowledged.

The same night. In the same hours as the attacks on the fridges, the air-raid alert apps of Ukraine and Russia showed false nuclear alerts. Kyiv blamed Moscow; the Russian app had been hit too, and nobody claimed it (TweakTown). Cyber warfare does not have a single author.

The same yardstick for prevention. Those who ask Moscow to stop the groups operating from its territory must ask European operators to close the doors they leave open. The two responsibilities do not exclude each other.

OUR JUDGMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

The suspicion towards pro-Russian groups is well founded: they have a record, they boasted, and two Western governments have documented their links with the Russian state. But a well-founded suspicion is not proof, and the difference matters precisely because the political consequences are large. Authorities that speak of "hybrid war" should publish what they know, as Denmark did for the water plant.

In the meantime there is something that can be done without waiting for any attribution: update the software and take exposed panels off the network. It costs little, and it is the defence that would have prevented freezers at 50 degrees.

WHAT TO WATCH

- The investigations by Belgian prosecutors and national authorities: whether anyone publishes technical evidence about the perpetrator.
- Whether the Commission or the Council formally attributes the attacks, and whether they use the cyber sanctions regime.
- Verification of the sample of Danfoss credentials published by NoName057(16).
- New attacks against the cold rooms of hospitals, transfusion centres and food warehouses.
- The numbers: how many of the exposed systems are secured.

Sources: GreenMe · Informat.ro · QN · Teleborsa · Cybernews · Euronews · RetailDetail · TweakTown · Open · ItaliaOggi · Al Jazeera · Informat.ro · Cybernews · Agenda Digitale · Kyiv Independent · Pillitteri, summarising the DOJ, the Danish government and Forescout · AFP, via Macau Business · dev.ua · Liga.net · ICJ · ICJ

2/2 · OPINION · 8 NOVEMBER 2026

Rearmament is a dish best served cold

On the night of 2 November the freezers of hundreds of supermarkets, in at least eleven European countries, rose to 50 degrees. Nobody forced a door: someone got into control software left exposed online, often old, sometimes with the factory password (the facts here). Two pro-Russian groups claimed responsibility, without verified evidence. Within a few days the episode was absorbed into a bigger story, the one about hybrid war and a Europe that must rearm. The countermeasures experts pointed to, however, were of another order: take the panels off the network, change the passwords, update the software. For the freezers, that was enough.

Let me start with what must be conceded, because it is true. The threat exists. The groups that claimed the attacks have a record, and two Western governments have documented their links with the Russian state. Ukraine has the right to defend itself, and helping it do so is lawful. Those who say that appointing a European envoy today to negotiate with Moscow would be a gift to the Kremlin have a serious argument: in May Russia threatened foreign diplomats in Kyiv, and Kaja Kallas maintains that Europe cannot be a neutral mediator, because it stands with the victim of aggression (Euronews). Perhaps she is right. Perhaps an envoy today would only get a refusal. I do not know. But I do know something else: the question is not whether Europe should defend itself, but how fast its two hands move, the one that arms and the one that negotiates.

And here is the point. The SAFE regulation, 150 billion in loans for defence, was proposed on 19 March 2025 and adopted on 27 May: about ten weeks (EU Council). To move fast, Article 122 of the Treaties was used, the emergency clause that leaves the European Parliament out, so much so that Parliament took the Council to the Court of Justice (La Notizia). The idea of an envoy for the negotiations had been under discussion since March 2025 (Politico, via Torre); in May 2026 ministers decided to postpone it until the demands to be made of Moscow are defined (Table.Media). For weapons, the emergency. For peace, the preconditions. The same imbalance shows in the budget: the proposal for 2028-2034 multiplies funds for defence and space by five (Commission, via FastForward), while the instrument that also funds conflict prevention faces a cut twice as deep as the rest (IRC). Emergency procedures, joint loans, budgets multiplied by five, a Parliament left out. And for diplomacy, a postponement.

Not all of Europe thinks the same way, and it is right to say so. France, Italy, Austria and Belgium have openly asked to open a channel with Moscow; Germany, Poland, the Baltic and Nordic countries prefer to increase the pressure (Euronews). In June the President of the European Council, António Costa, had his cabinet open a contact with the Kremlin: several

governments protested because they had not been consulted, and those contacts served only to open a line, without going into substance (Euronews). The problem is not that someone wants war. It is that rearmament has fast tools, ready to use, and diplomacy does not: appointing an envoy takes the unanimity of twenty-seven governments, and a single no is enough to stop everything. So, with every new alarm, the easiest response to approve is always the same. There is no need to imagine a conspiracy. It is enough to look at which door opens with the least effort.

On this site we wrote, in a manifesto, that before any choice of force it should be possible to show that the path of negotiation had truly been exhausted, not abandoned halfway ("We Will Not Look Away While War Is Chosen"). Today that proof does not exist: a line opened without a mandate is not a negotiation attempted. So far, others have done the negotiating. For the freezers, a new password was enough. For peace, a name and a mandate would be enough. After more than a year and a half, we are still looking for them.

Sources: Euronews · EU Council · La Notizia · Politico, via Torre · Table.Media · Commission, via FastForward · IRC · Euronews · Euronews

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N3R1-70 — I Will Not Look Away — Online version: https://iwillnotlookaway.org/s/en/series-peace-rearmament-full-text.html